Nyamjang Chu that flows into India from Tibet. Khenzemane was dominated by the eastern spur of the Thagla massif, while to its right lay the crest line on which Bum-la was situated. Further downstream, the Nyamjang Chu flowed under the Drokung Samba Bridge after which the Nam Ka Chu coming in at right angles from the west joined it two kilometres south of Khenzemane. After the confluence, the Nyamjang Chu flowed along the side of the Tsangdhar spur before entering the relatively broad valley at Zimithang. The river then passed through scenic jungle, flanked on the right by elevated plateaus, which were cultivated by the Monpa people.

The Nyamjang Chu was joined by the Tawang Chu just south of Lumla, from where the river entered Bhutanese territory and then continued southwards running parallel to the NEFA border before entering Assam as the Manas River. The Tawang Chu, flowing from east to west, separated the Tawang slopes on the northern side while on the southern side, the Se-la massif rose almost vertically. Once across the pass, the tracks dropped down to Dirang Dzong and onto Bomdila, from where one entered the plains of Assam by crossing yet another densely forested ridgeline known as Eaglenest.

Even though General Thorat, the Eastern Army Commander had clearly indicated that for the defence of the Kameng Frontier Division, the Bomdila–Manda-la ridge should be the vital ground, Division HQ kept pushing troops forward although there was little logistical support available. Jeeps and light vehicles could only ply as far as Bomdila, beyond which movement was entirely dependent on porters and hill ponies. The Border Roads Organisation had been tasked with extending the road, but at the time it took seven days to get from Bomdila to Tawang. 5 Assam Rifles, which was previously responsible for the area, had small shelters en route which were used as staging camps.

Major General Amrik Singh, GOC 4 Division, had attended the Lucknow conference where Exercise Lal Qila was held. He had returned to Tezpur echoing the sentiment prevalent in Delhi rather than Lucknow. He let it be known that, in his opinion, the Eastern Army Commander had been rather ‘vague’ as he did not have any first-hand knowledge of the ground, having ‘prepared his assessment off a map’. Though the Thorat Plan suggested keeping the bulk of the troops south of Se-la, Amrik Singh